

Christmas Easter Observance

prc-christmas-easter-observance

Calendar & Customs · Holy Days · practice · divided_lineages · brethren distinctive

DISPUTED

score 0.762
confidence medium

Statement under examination

The observance of Christmas and Easter (Resurrection Sunday) is a matter of Christian liberty (Romans 14:5-6); the Christian calendar is not commanded in the New Testament but neither is its observance forbidden.

In plain language

The words in the two anchor passages do not name Christmas or Easter at all. In Romans 14:5 Paul uses *krino*, to judge or esteem, for someone who rates one day above another, and *plerophoreo*, to be fully convinced, telling each person to settle the matter in his own mind, *idios nous*. In 14:6 both the one who keeps the day and the one who does not are said to act *kurio*, to the Lord, and to give thanks to God, *eucharistei* to *theo*. That language frames the day question as personal conviction held before God, which is the textual root of a liberty reading. In Colossians 2:16 Paul says let no one judge you over a feast, a new moon, or sabbaths, and in 2:17 he calls these a shadow of things to come whose body belongs to Christ. The three words there, *heorte*, *noumenia*, and *sabbaton*, are the standard Septuagint terms for the Jewish festal calendar, and *noumenia* in fact appears nowhere else in the New Testament, which fixes its sense entirely from the old covenant cult. So the text closes the old required calendar but says nothing about any later Christian holiday. The complication is Galatians 4:10, where Paul rebukes people who observe days and months and seasons and years, and shows alarm in 4:11. The same Greek word *paratereo* elsewhere in the canon describes hostile watching, and Paul links the calendar there to weak elemental principles. On the bare words alone a reader can build a case that uncommanded days are a free matter held before the Lord, and another reader can build a case that observing days the New Testament never commands is exactly what Paul warns against. The lexicon supplies two patterns and does not rank them. Because the specific holidays in the proposition are never named in the canon, the precise claim is left unsettled by the text itself. The verdict is recorded as disputed for that reason. The underlying vocabulary about days and conviction is clear, but its application to the Christian calendar is an inference the words neither make nor close.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
G1035	βρῶσις	brōsis	eating	
G1859	ἐορτή	heorte	festival	26
G2168	εὐχαριστέω	eucharisteo	to thank	38
G2250	ἡμέρα	hemera	day	392
G2919	κρίνω	krino	to judge	115
G3195	μέλλω	mello	to ensue	111
G3313	μέρος	meros	part	
G3561	νουμηνία	noumenia	New Moon	1

G3563	νοῦς	nous	mind	24
G3906	παρατηρέω	paratereo	to observe	6
G4135	πληροφορέω	plerophoreo	to fulfill	6
G4213	πόσις	posis	drink	
G4521	σάββατον	sabbaton	Sabbath	68
G4639	σκιά	skia	shadow	7
G4983	σῶμα	soma	body	144
G5426	φρονέω	phroneo	to reason	30

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: False

Romans 14:5 puts *krinei hemeran par hemeran* (esteems one day above another) against *krinei pasan hemeran* (esteems every day alike) and settles the dispute by *hekastos en to idio noi plerophoreistho*, let each be fully convinced in his own mind, with both parties acting *kurio* and giving thanks *eucharisto* to *theo* in 14:6. That grammar lexically authorises a liberty reading. Colossians 2:16 forbids judging *en merei heortes e noumenias e sabbaton*, exactly the triad of festival, new moon, and sabbath that is the technical Mosaic calendar in the Septuagint, and 2:17 classes them as *skia ton mellonton*, shadow of things to come, whose *soma* belongs to Christ. Neither passage names Christmas or Easter; the canon never mentions them. Galatians 4:10 rebukes *hemeras paratereisthe kai menas kai kairous kai eniautous* as a return to weak *stoicheia*, so the same vocabulary about observing days can be censured. The lexicon therefore yields two unranked patterns. A liberty pattern from Romans 14 and a censure pattern from Galatians 4. The specific application to a post-canonical Christian calendar is an inference the words neither make nor close.

Scripture

Rom.14.5 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2919 κρίνω, G2250 ἡμέρα, G4135 πληροφορέω, G3563 νοῦς

Force. *krinei hemeran par hemeran*, esteems one day beyond another, is set against *krinei pasan hemeran*, esteems every day alike. The resolution is not a command for or against observance but *hekastos en to idio noi plerophoreistho*, let each be fully convinced in his own mind. The lexical weight falls on *idios nous*, personal conviction, and on *plerophoreo*, to be fully assured. That is the textual root of the liberty reading.

Rom.14.6 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G5426 φρονέω, G2168 εὐχαριστέω, G2250 ἡμέρα

Force. *ho phronon ten hemeran kyrio phronei*, the one who minds the day minds it to the Lord, parallels *ho esthion kyrio esthie*, *eucharistei gar to theo*, the one who eats does so to the Lord, for he gives thanks to God. The verse frames opposing practices as alike God-directed and bracketed by thanksgiving, which supports a liberty reading where the matter is held *coram Deo* rather than legislated for the body.

Col.2.16 · **for** · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2919 κρίνω, G1859 ἑορτή, G3561 νουμηνία, G4521 σάββατον

Force. me oun tis hymas krineto, let no one therefore judge you, governs en brosei kai en posei, in food and drink, then a festal triad, en merei heortes e noumenias e sabbaton, a feast or new moon or sabbaths. The triad heorte, noumenia, sabbaton matches the recurring Septuagint cultic formula for the Mosaic calendar (compare 1Chr.23.31, 2Chr.2.4, 2Chr.31.3, Hos.2.11, Ezek.45.17). noumenia is a true New Testament hapax, occurring only here, and its sense is anchored entirely by that Septuagint background. The technical referent is the old covenant calendar, not the later Christian one, which the canon never names.

Col.2.17 · **neutral** · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G4639 σκιά, G4983 σῶμα, G3195 μέλλω

Force. ha estin skia ton mellonton, which are a shadow of the coming things, to de soma tou Christou, but the body is of Christ. The same skia and soma contrast recurs in Heb.8.5 and Heb.10.1 for the tabernacle and the law respectively, which fixes the sense: the named days are typological forecast already fulfilled. The verse closes the old calendar as binding but says nothing about days the New Testament neither names nor commands.

Gal.4.10 · **complicates** · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2250 ἡμέρα, G3906 παρατηρέω

Force. hemeras paratereisthe kai menas kai kairous kai eniautous, you observe days and months and seasons and years. paratereo in the middle voice in Galatians, with Paul's alarm in 4:11 (phoboumai hymas), names calendar observance as a return to ta asthene kai ptocha stoicheia (4:9). The same verb elsewhere in the canon (Mark.3.2, Luke.6.7, Luke.14.1, Luke.20.20, Acts.9.24) describes hostile or scheming watching, which colours the rebuke. This supplies the lexical ground for a regulative reading that cuts against an unqualified liberty verdict.

Heb.10.1 · **neutral** · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G4639 σκιά, G3195 μέλλω

Force. skian gar echon ho nomos ton mellonton agathon, for the law has a shadow of the good things to come. The same lexical pairing as Col.2.17 (skia plus mello) fixes the referent of the Colossians triad to the Mosaic typological system. This is the canon-internal lexical cross-check that the festal language in Col.2.16 is about the old calendar.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Col.2.16	Lev.23.1	tsk	1
Col.2.16	Lev.16.31	tsk	1
Col.2.16	Num.10.10	tsk	1
Col.2.16	Lev.11.2	tsk	1
Rom.14.6	Exod.12.14	tsk	1
Col.2.17	Heb.10.1	openbible	1
Col.2.17	Heb.8.5	openbible	1

Complicating texts

Gal.4.10 · addressed

Galatians 4:10 censures observing hemeras kai menas kai kairous kai eniautous and supplies a lexical ground for treating calendar observance as transgression. The text-internal resolution is that in Galatians the days are bound to ta stoicheia tou kosmou (4:3, 4:9) and to a works-righteous return to bondage, while Romans 14 frames day-esteeming as personal conviction held kurio with thanksgiving. The two passages pull in opposite directions on the bare lexicon, which is why the verdict is disputed rather than affirmed. The vocabulary does not rank the two patterns.

Col.2.16 · addressed

The triad heorte, noumenia, sabbaton is the technical Septuagint Mosaic festal vocabulary and noumenia is a New Testament hapax legomenon attested only here, so its sense is fixed entirely by Old Testament cultic legislation. The verse therefore removes any binding obligation to keep the old calendar but neither authorises nor prohibits a later post-canonical Christian calendar, which the lexicon does not name. The specific proposition is left underdetermined by the words.

Concordance traversed

G2250, G2919, G4135, G3563, G5426, G2168, G1859, G3561, G4521, G4639, G4983, G3906, G3195, G1035, G4213, G3313

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

rom-14-6-kai-ho-me-phronon at Rom.14.6: impact none. Some witnesses add kai ho me phronon ten hemeran kyrio ou phronei, the one who does not observe the day does not observe to the Lord. The addition reinforces the symmetry of observance and non-observance and does not alter the liberty-versus-regulative balance.

col-2-16-e-en-merei at Col.2.16: impact none. Minor connective variation between e and kai inside the festal list does not change the referent, the Mosaic calendar triad, nor the verdict.

Both anchor passages lie outside the open-cbqm 3 John sample, so CBQM was not run. The variants examined are editorial-apparatus level and do not touch the verdict.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. redemptive-historical

Frameworks in play. liberty_of_conscience, regulative_principle, shadow_fulfillment, covenant_theology, dispensationalism, new_covenant_theology

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

liberty_of_conscience: affirms · Romans 14:5-6 leaves day-esteeming to idios nous, personal conviction, with both observance and non-observance referred kurio and bracketed by eucharistei to theo. A day the New Testament neither commands nor forbids therefore falls under this same liberty, and commemoration of the incarnation or resurrection by those persuaded to do so is licit so long as it is not imposed.

regulative_principle: denies · Worship elements not commanded by Scripture are excluded. Galatians 4:10 names paratero of hemeras kai menas kai kairous kai eniautous as a return to stoicheia, and Colossians 2:17 abolishes the festal shadow without instituting a replacement. On this reading an uncommanded Christian calendar is not a free matter in corporate worship but disallowed by silence, since the New Testament prescribes the Lord's day and the Lord's Supper and no annual feasts.

shadow_fulfillment: neutral · Colossians 2:17 classes the Mosaic festal triad as skia ton mellonton whose soma is Christ, and Hebrews 10:1 uses the same skia plus mello pairing for the whole law. This abolishes the old calendar without naming or settling any later one, so the lexicon as such leaves the post-canonical question undecided.

pagan_origins_objection: denies · The lexicon does not contain Christmas or Easter, so this lens cannot be settled by the words alone. Read on its strongest lexical footing it appeals to the regulative pull of Galatians 4:10 against syncretism with the calendar of the surrounding culture, by analogy with the deuteronomic warnings against the religious customs of the nations. The analogy is extracanonical reasoning, but the underlying lexical worry, that days bound up with the wrong devotion can become a snare, is in the text.

The verdict turns on whether a day neither commanded nor forbidden falls under Romans 14 liberty or under the regulative exclusion implied by Galatians 4:10. The lexicon supports both readings and the shadow-fulfillment line resolves only the old calendar, so analogia scripturae does not collapse the question to a single verdict.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Does the New Testament treat the esteeming of particular days, where a day is neither commanded nor forbidden, as a matter left to individual conviction, or does it restrict observance to what is commanded?

The phrases matter of Christian liberty and not commanded but neither forbidden encode the adiaphora conclusion that the liberty side of the dispute reaches. The regulative reading would deny that an uncommanded day is a free matter. The verdict is derived on the original stem, but the audit records that the stem leans toward the liberty side before the evidence is weighed.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Rom.14.5
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Col.2.16
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Gal.4.10
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2919
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1859
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3561
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G4639
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3906
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G4135
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Col.2.16
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Col.2.17
interlinear	Nestle1904-text	public_domain	yes	Col.2.17

License audit

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Nestle1904-text	public_domain	yes

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